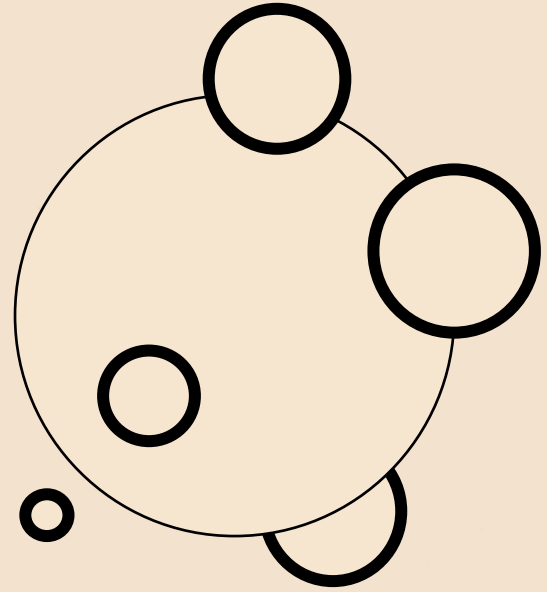


THE AVURIAN PLANETARIUM

The party step into a large hemi-spherical chamber housing the Avurian Planetarium, a grand arcane device depicting the turning of celestial bodies about a central world. From the inside of a large dome crafted in bronze and decorated with reliefs of gods and heroes of ancient legends, the party look across a three tiered floor - a central platform on which stands the bronze globe of the world, an artificial moat surrounding that, and then finally a ring of flat metal at the edge of the circular floor and upon which the party currently find themselves.

On the central platform, at its centre, a short podium holds aloft an intricately patterned globe which can at once be seen to depict the entire material world in spherical form.

From the podium beneath the globe, five balance arms are held aloft which arch across the room, reaching out at different lengths around the globe to hold in place five satellites, each a smaller globe. The arms now rest dormant, but the smaller globe farthest from the central seems to be open just a crack, and a yellow light is dimly shining out of it.



This is a puzzle designed to test a party's physical and mental skills. It is not a room of combat, but rather one in which a party will need to test themselves by plunging into a working mechanism in order to operate it properly.

From the start the mechanism is dormant and requires that an item be placed within the farthest globe. Once this is done though, the mechanism will activate and start to move. Each outer globe must then be opened and solved in turn, each time making the danger of the mechanism worse.

KEY ITEMS

A core component of this puzzle is that the party must place five objects within the satellite globes which turn about the mechanism. Each object is a specially designed key which the designers of the mechanism intended to be used to test any who would use this place.

These objects can be anything you as DM desire, and can inform the actual purpose of the device. Here are some suggestions for keys to use, and the effects that might have should the party successfully complete the puzzle.

- ✧ *Five gems, each radiating a different colour, must be found from either across the world or within this specific dungeon. These gems were specifically crafted to be keys which would unlock a chamber within the central globe, scattered by the builder of this place so that only those who put sincere effort into assembling those keys can possibly claim the prize within.*

- ✧ *The central orb contains a stasis chamber, in which an ancient Wizard hides from his greatest enemies. Only when those enemies are slain and proof of their deaths (such as their skulls, key possessions, etc) are placed within the outer orbs can the Wizard be freed and his secrets learned.*
- ✧ *This mighty device was built to imbue objects with magical power. Into each orb the party must place one of their own possessions, risking their own gear for the gamble of greater utility. Successfully utilizing the mechanism results in the central orb opening and the five items all being transported there to the middle, but now imbued with new magical properties.*
- ✧ *A wondrous device built by ancient mages, a party can place five items within the outer globes all of which are owned or relate directly to a specific object or person, the five pieces forming a code or address which the device interprets. If their logic is sound enough, the device will locate the thing or person the users desire, and transport it directly to them. The central globe will open having exhausted and destroyed the five offered items, and instead the desired object will be there for claiming.*

The exact purpose of the device, and what it can hold or do for the party, has been left deliberately vague so that you as DM can come up with your own ideas and tailor the device for a specific purpose suited to your own game. Maybe your party need better magic items, or specific blessings to defeat certain enemies, or maybe they need a particular item or person from long ago or far away to succeed in other tasks. Whatever your party need, this device can be solved and used to accomplish their goal.

The chamber is perfectly circular and hemispherical, with a radius of 60ft in all three-dimensional directions.

The floor, having a diameter of 120ft, is set out in three tiers - an outer ring 10ft wide runs around the outside, a platform 60ft in diameter at its centre. Between these two rings a moat 20ft wide sits filled with stale, resting water which has been in place since this room was built.

The floor, like the entirety of the rest of the room, is crafted from molded bronze and is clearly a wonder of engineering skill and craftsmanship. It is also clearly preserved by some magical means, the entire room being in pristine condition despite many long years of its existence. There is no sign of rust or discolouring, and the standing water in the moat remains completely full. The nature of this magic can not be easily discerned however.

A 10ft high bronze podium 2ft wide raises from the very centre of the floor, and upon this sits the large 20ft wide globe at the heart of the chamber patterned to show a relief of the landmasses of the entire world. Highs and lows of the land, as well as every body of water can be made out, perfectly designed to show the world at the time of the device's construction. The arms reach out from recesses in the podium to hold the satellites around the room, the nearest passing only a foot from the central globe, and the farthest barely skimming the outer edge of the dome. At the end of each arm a smaller 5ft wide globe is held out.

The dome itself is molded bronze like the rest of the room and its contents, patterned with reliefs depicting heroes and gods, At the floor level the heroes battle, a few standing out and reaching out from the combat towards the top point of the chamber. From this central point, amongst thick clouds, gods of good and evil together reach down towards the heroes.

There are no gaps in this dome other than the passage through which the party entered.

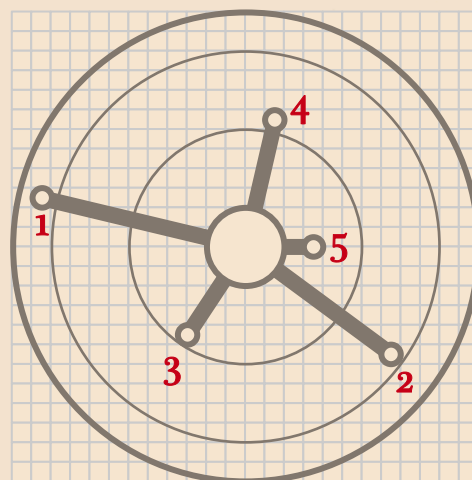
At the time the party enter the chamber, the entire mechanism sits still and idle. The party can freely move around it and examine it, and find that the four satellites closest to middle are all sealed. The one farthest out however has a crack in it, having been partially but not fully opened, and from the crack comes a dim white light.

FIRST SATELLITE

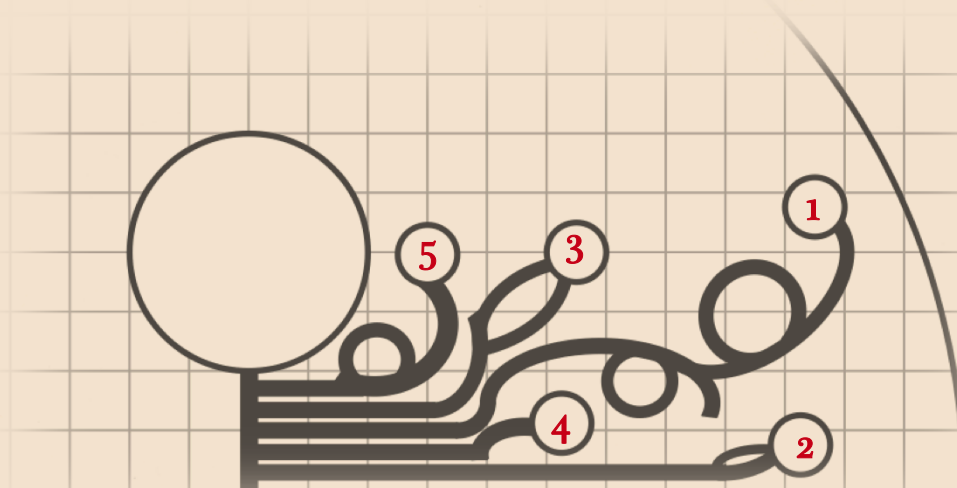
The outermost orb rests oft above the ground, light shining from within through a crack in its surface. If it can not be reached by mundane or magical means, such as jumping or being held aloft, then a character will need to find another way to reach it.

Climbing and crossing the stationary arms - DC12 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Climbing the outer wall relief - DC20 Strength (Athletics)



Top-down view of chamber, with satellite arms in starting positions



Profile diagram of the central globe and outstretched arms with satellite globes

Once a character is on the top of one of the arms or at one of the globes, they are stable enough to not fall and have no great risk of injury. Any fall due to clumsiness or other external factors will only momentarily cause a character to gain the Stunned condition.

Upon reaching the first satellite a character will get a better look at the star motifs which cover its surface, and the crack in its side. The inner surface of the shell emits the faint magically induced light which the party saw shining out of it, and the shell stands already slightly opened when the party entered the chamber. It can be pulled apart fairly easily, as after only a little effort the mechanism will activate itself and open half the shell as normal. The globe is clearly designed so that half of its surface folds into the other, revealing a flat platform within with slight grooves on its surface which suggest that an item could fit very neatly there.

Once an Key Item has been placed in the open globe, whether a specific key or an object which better suits your own purpose for the device, the shell closes again and the device comes to life. Incredibly smoothly, without even a shudder, the arms of the device begin to turn about the chamber at a slow speed. Each makes an eighth of a turn about the chamber every round (six seconds), the first, third and fifth arms moving clockwise, the second and fourth arms moving counter-clockwise. After the arms all make one full turn about the chamber and pass their starting positions again, the FOURTH satellite's globe will open, revealing another flat platform lit by the inner surface of the globe.

It is best at this point to take Initiative scores for the entire party so that you can keep track of their actions in time with the rotations of the arms. The simplest method for the DM is that the arms always move at Initiative step 20, however you can add variation to make the puzzle more interesting by giving each arm an Initiative score of their own. Setting them at 5, 10, 15, 20 and 25 will create a decent spread, or you can roll to add some chaos into the matter.

As the rings have started to move, the difficulty of reaching them and the danger posed to characters upon them will increase. Yet with the opening of the fourth globe it should be clear to the party that the next Key Item needs to be placed within, but climbing along the arms is now trickier and poses new hazards.

Climbing and crossing the arms - DC15 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Climbing the outer wall relief - DC20 Strength (Athletics)

Jumping from arm to arm - DC12 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Timing the jump a jump, giving Advantage to the

roll - DC12 Wisdom (Insight)

The speed at which the arms are currently moving are not enough to do serious damage, but have strength enough to push anything they hit. Any character caught in the path of one of the lower arms can easily step aside, but if they are occupied at the time they will merely be pushed along with it. Should they be atop one of the arm when they are pushed though, they will be knocked off of it and onto the ground. They will take 1d4 Bludgeoning damage and find themselves Prone on the floor beneath the arms.

FOURTH SATELLITE

Placing a Key Item inside the fourth satellite will be followed by that globe sealing itself, and the arms picking up speed. Each now makes quarter of a turn around the chamber every round (six seconds). After the second full rotation the SECOND satellite will open, revealing a flat platform lit by the inner shell as before.

Climbing and crossing the arms - DC18 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Climbing the outer wall relief - DC20 Strength (Athletics)

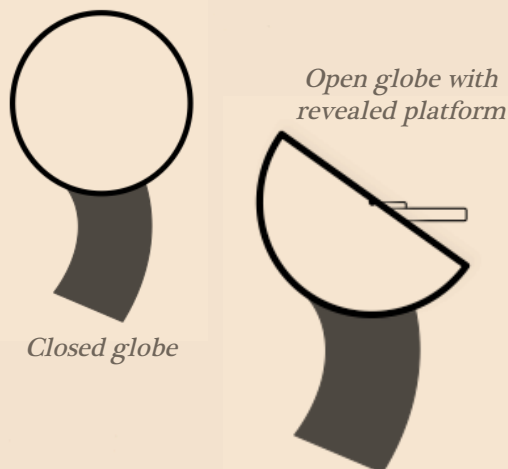
Jumping from arm to arm - DC15 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Timing the jump a jump, giving Advantage to the roll - DC15 Wisdom (Insight)

Evading an oncoming arm - DC16 Dexterity saving throw, move 5ft out of the way if successful, take 1d6 Bludgeoning damage if failed.

Enduring the impact of an oncoming arm - DC16 Constitution saving throw, 1 bludgeoning damage and pushed with arm if successful, 1d6 bludgeoning damage and character is knocked Prone is failed. A character who succeeds on this saving throw can opt to hold on to the arm as it hits them, allowing them to clamber on top of it and move on from it in subsequent rounds.

Any fall from the arms or satellites will now cause 1d6 bludgeoning damage.



SECOND SATELLITE

Placing a Key Item inside the second satellite will again be followed by that globe sealing itself, and the arms once again increasing in speed. Each now makes half of a turn around the chamber every round (six seconds). After the third full rotation the FIFTH satellite - the one closest to the central globe - will open, revealing a flat platform lit by the inner shell as before.

Climbing and crossing the arms - DC21 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Climbing the outer wall relief - DC20 Strength (Athletics)

Jumping from arm to arm - DC20 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Timing the jump a jump, giving Advantage to the roll - DC20 Wisdom (Insight)

Evading an oncoming arm - DC19 Dexterity saving throw, move 5ft out of the way if successful, take 1d8 Bludgeoning damage if failed.

Enduring the impact of an oncoming arm - DC19 Constitution saving throw, 2 bludgeoning damage and pushed with arm if successful, 1d8 bludgeoning damage and character is knocked Prone is failed. A character who succeeds on this saving throw can opt to hold on to the arm as it hits them, allowing them to clamber on top of it and move on from it in subsequent rounds.

Any fall from the arms or satellites will now cause 1d8 bludgeoning damage.

To make matters worse, after the third satellite has been activated and closed, the moat of water will IGNITE. Despite it appearing to be simple water, it now erupts into flames. Any character in those flames at the time it ignites takes 1d6 Fire damage. In subsequent rounds, any characters who start their turn in the flames takes a further 1d6 Fire damage.

FIFTH SATELLITE

Placing a Key Item inside the fifth satellite will again be followed by that globe sealing itself, and the arms once again increasing in speed. Each now makes a full turn around the chamber every round (six seconds). After the fourth full rotation the THIRD and middle satellite will open, revealing a flat platform lit by the inner shell as before.

Climbing and crossing the arms - DC25 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Climbing the outer wall relief - DC20 Strength (Athletics)

Jumping from arm to arm - DC25 Dexterity (Acrobatics)

Timing the jump a jump, giving Advantage to the roll - DC20 Wisdom (Insight)

Evading an oncoming arm - DC22 Dexterity saving throw, move 5ft out of the way if successful, take 2d6 Bludgeoning damage if failed.

Enduring the impact of an oncoming arm - DC22

Constitution saving throw, 5 bludgeoning damage and pushed with arm if successful, 2d6 bludgeoning damage and character is knocked Prone is failed. A character who succeeds on this saving throw can opt to hold on to the arm as it hits them, allowing them to clamber on top of it and move on from it in subsequent rounds.

Any fall from the arms or satellites will now cause 1d10 bludgeoning damage.

The heat of the flames in the moat now intensify, shifting into a blue flame which sears to the touch. Any character who starts their turn inside the flames takes 2d6 Fire damage.

THIRD SATELLITE

Placing the final key item in the third and final satellite globe results in the final globe sealing itself. All of the globes are now sealed, but the arms do not immediately stop moving. Rather they pick up even more speed.

Four more rounds will pass during which the arms will continue to spin, each time becoming one half turn faster - so in the round immediately after the globe closes the arms make a full turn, followed by a turn and a half in the next round, two full turn in the round after that, and then a turn and a half in the round after that.

Characters in the path of the arms or still actively on them have the choice of how to react, either hanging on for dear life or trying to jump to safety. One of the following saves should be made on the second round after the third globe has closed.

Hang on to increasingly fast spinning arm - DC20 Constitution Saving Throw. If failed the character is flung from the device and takes 1d10 Bludgeoning damage as they hit the ground. They have a one in six chance of being thrown to the far edge of the room where they are safe in future rounds, and also a one in six chance of landing in the flaming moat. A character who starts a round in the moat takes 2d6 Fire damage.

Jump under the arms and try to find safety there - DC20 Wisdom Saving Throw. If failed the character lands awkwardly, and not flat on the ground. They are at risk of being hit by a further arm as it spins around, in which case they can repeat this save or else take 2d6 Bludgeoning damage.

Move along the arms to a better spot to jump to safety - DC20 Strength Saving Throw. If passed the character is able to pull themselves along one of the arms to a point where they can jump to safety. They can subsequently make a DC20 Dexterity Saving Throw with Advantage. Regardless of that result, they land on the outer edge of the room away from the arms, however if they fail they also take 2d6 Bludgeoning damage.

After the fourth turn the spinning arms will slowly start to reduce their speed, the mechanism being done and its purpose complete. With all four globes filled and sealed, and its final spin cycle complete, the arms slowly and smoothly come to a full stop. Once stopped, or at a slow speed, characters can disembark from the device with ease, however if they were on the arms for an extended time they might be momentarily Stunned due to dizziness.

With the device done, the central globe opens along an extremely fine, previously unseen seam, and light from within spills out into the chamber, again being cast by a magical light along the inside of the globe. At the centre of the central globe the party's prize stands, ready for them to claim.

After the party have claimed their prize, and as they begin to walk away from the device, it will reset itself to its starting positions. The inner globe closes, the arms rest to the starting places, and the first, outer globe opens a crack, just as it was when the party first entered the chamber.



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There is a potential for a fair amount of damage to be taken within the device, especially for a lower level party.
As the arms begin to get faster and faster, the chances of a character fumbling a roll get higher, and they can soon find themselves falling from the device's arms, being struck by others, or falling into the flaming moat as well.
If this is the case and you feel like being merciful to your player party, then the magical light on the inside of the central globe can also be said to have healing properties which help them to restore after this ordeal. Should a short rest betaken in the chamber next to the device, then any healing can be doubled, and the device will not reset until the party actually leave.

In case the more ornate design of the spinning arms is a little too complicated to describe, this alternate design is offered. Satellites in this version pass much closer to each other, with no arms passing over each other and risking knocking a character off.

